

Using regulation meters to aid in research

A Brief Guide to using regulation meters to support individuals with additional needs during the research process

REGULATION METERS

Regulation meters can prepare people with additional needs to express their opinions on important subjects. This system uses coloured regulation zones to allow people to share how they feel about a topic (things we do at school, in this example). Open-ended questions guide the discussion, and individuals choose which zone they associate with the topic item.

HOW DO WE DO IT?

STEP ONE;

Think about your topic. It should be something you can ask open-ended questions about, like "How do you feel about [thing we do at school]?" instead of just "Do you like school?"

STEP TWO;

Set up the regulation meter. there should be;

- The regulation meter
- Symbols related to the topic (i.e., things we do at school, so reading, maths, etc)
- Space next to the regulation meter to enable the individual to put the symbols down

STEP THREE;

Explain the activity to the student by, for example, talking through a narrative for anxiety. (See our other guidance on narratives for anxiety)

STEP FOUR;

Gain consent from the student you are working with (see our other guidance on consent procedures)



Reading

STEP FIVE;

Introduce the conversation, e.g. Let's talk about things we do at school. I will show you some things we do at school, and I'd like you to place it next to how you feel about it.

Hand the individual each symbol and ask "how do you feel about?..."

STEP SIX;

When the symbol has been placed, read it back to the individual (i.e., reading is in the green zone?) and give them the opportunity to make any changes.

If appropriate with the student you are working with, follow up with each symbol (i.e., why did you put reading in the green zone?)

THINGS TO CONSIDER

- Have some sticky notes on hand to create new symbols as the conversation goes along.
- Get an understanding of the individuals level of symbolic representation... would they be better with photographs?
- If using symbols, consider which symbol set will be most recognisable for them (e.g. Widgit vs PCS)
- Build trust and connection with the individual before having these conversations
- Work closely with the individual and those who know them best to ensure that the questions/format respect their communication style